

The Design Pitch

7 Questions

12-Item Word Sort

Gap Fill

Answer Key

Language, Narrative & Persuasion

B2 Worksheet · Professional English for Designers & Creative Directors



ACTIVITY 01 ·

Reading Comprehension & Vocabulary

Multiple Choice · 7 Questions · circle the best answer (A, B, C or D)

01

Instructions: Each question presents a scenario from a professional design pitch. Circle or underline the best answer (A, B, C or D). Check your answers on the Answer Key pages at the back.

Q1

A junior designer is presenting her concept for a cultural centre to a panel of clients. She wants to open with a strong statement about the idea's origin.

Which phrase would most effectively open a design narrative?

A

This project is basically about making a building near the waterfront area.

B

The concept grew out of a tension between public accessibility and private contemplation.

C

We decided to use concrete because it was suggested by the structural engineer.

D

The brief asked for a 2,000 sq metre facility with flexible seating options.

Q2

A designer is explaining why the spatial layout of her proposal is unconventional. She wants to justify her reasoning without sounding defensive.

Which phrase introduces a design decision in the most confident and professional way?

A

We tried to do something different because the usual approach felt limiting to us.

B

The client didn't specify this, but we felt it might be worth exploring further.

C

Rather than defaulting to a conventional corridor typology, we organised spaces around a central void.

D

As you can see, we moved things around to make it feel more modern and interesting.

Q3

During a pitch, a client says: 'I am not sure this fits our brand identity.' The designer needs to respond constructively.

Which response best demonstrates professional communication and keeps the conversation productive?

A

That's a valid concern. Could you help me understand which elements feel misaligned? That would let us refine the direction together.

B

We actually think it does fit your brand — the moodboard we showed earlier makes that quite clear.

C

Brand identity is quite subjective, so it is hard to say definitively whether it truly fits.

D

We can change anything — just tell us your preference and we will adjust the whole concept.

Q4

A designer needs to explain an abstract concept — that a building should dissolve into its landscape rather than impose upon it.

Which sentence most clearly articulates this design intention to a non-specialist client?

A

We are using low-carbon materials to reduce the environmental footprint of the structure.

B

The building is designed to feel as though it has always been part of the site — its edges blur into the terrain.

C

The roof will be planted and the cladding will use natural tones drawn from a site palette.

D

We referenced several precedents from Scandinavian landscape architecture to inform our approach.

Q5

At the end of a pitch, the designer wants to invite questions and signal the proposal is still open to iteration.

Which closing statement best balances confidence with openness to further dialogue?

A

This is our final proposal and we are fully confident it satisfies the brief as stated.

B

We are honestly not yet sure this is the right direction — we would love your thoughts first.

C

We are presenting this as a strong direction rather than a fixed solution — we would welcome your reactions.

D

Please take your time to review the drawings and we will follow up by email next week.

Q6

A designer is explaining the narrative thread that connects all the design decisions in a residential project.

What does the term 'design narrative' most accurately refer to in a professional context?

A

The chronological story of the construction process from planning to completion

B

The written description submitted alongside formal planning permission applications

C

A coherent framework of ideas that gives meaning and logic to each design decision

D

The marketing text used to promote a completed project in press releases or social media

Q7

A product designer says: 'We need to foreground the material qualities in the presentation — tactility is central to the concept.'

What does the word 'foreground' mean in this sentence?

A

To physically position the object at the front of the display table during the presentation

B

To emphasise something or make it the most prominent element of the presentation

C

To photograph the object against a simple, uncluttered neutral background for slides

D

To carry out materials research and testing before the design process formally begins

Sort the Pitch Vocabulary

02

Word Sorting · 12 Phrases · write each phrase in the correct column below

Instructions: The 12 phrases in the word bank are all used in professional design pitches. Write each phrase in the correct column: **Starting a Narrative**, **Describing a Concept**, or **Responding to Feedback**. Each phrase belongs to one category only.

WORD BANK — sort these 12 phrases:

an honest expression of

a spatial tension between

At the heart of this proposal...

That's a useful point —

We can absolutely revisit...

conceptually driven by

That feedback helps us refine...

The driving idea behind this...

rooted in contrast

The concept stems from...

What we set out to explore...

Could you say more about...

WRITE EACH PHRASE IN THE CORRECT COLUMN:

Starting a Narrative

1.

2.

3.

4.

Describing a Concept

1.

2.

3.

4.

Responding to Feedback

1.

2.

3.

4.

Complete the Design Pitch

03

Gap Fill · 5 Sentences · circle the phrase (A, B, C or D) that best fits the gap

Instructions: A designer is presenting a concept for a new community library. Read each sentence and circle the letter of the phrase (A, B, C or D) that correctly completes the gap. Consider both grammatical fit and professional tone.

1

The idea for this library _____ the community's need for a space that feels both intimate and open to the public.

- A** was inspired somewhat. **B** grew directly out of **C** found its basis coming... **D** was conceptually found...

2

Rather than separating reading areas from gathering spaces, _____ them through layered thresholds that users can navigate intuitively.

- A** we chose to connect **B** we decided on linking **C** our proposal combines **D** our solution is connecti...

3

The materiality of the building _____ the surrounding landscape: timber and rammed earth echo the textures of the site.

- A** takes its cues closely f... **B** has been influenced di... **C** is in direct dialogue wit... **D** makes clear reference...

4

We understand your concern about budget — and _____
those constraints as opportunities to simplify and intensify the concept.

- A** our intention would be... **B** we could possibly con... **C** we are suggesting to h... **D** we would like to refra...

5

Ultimately, what we are proposing is not simply a building —
_____ a civic gesture: a space expressing the community's
belief in shared knowledge.

- A** it is an attempt to mak... **B** but rather we are creat... **C** what this represents h... **D** instead this is about m...

REFLECTION TASK

Instructions: Choose one sentence from Activity 03 and rewrite it in your own words, adapting it to a project you are currently working on or have worked on in the past. Try to use at least two vocabulary items from Activity 02 in your version.

Your chosen sentence number: _____

Your rewritten version:

ANSWER KEY

Complete all activities before consulting this page

Activity 01 — Multiple Choice

Q1. Correct answer: B — The concept grew out of a tension between public accessibility and private contemplation.

Why: Option B uses 'grew out of' — implying organic, conceptual development — and frames the idea around a compelling tension. Design pitches should open with an idea, not a specification or a technical constraint.

Q2. Correct answer: C — Rather than defaulting to a conventional corridor typology, we organised spaces around a central void.

Why: 'Rather than defaulting to' signals a deliberate, informed choice. Key structure: acknowledge the norm, then explain your departure from it.

Q3. Correct answer: A — That's a valid concern. Could you help me understand which elements feel misaligned? That would let us refine the direction together.

Why: Option A uses active listening, asks a clarifying question, and proposes collaboration. In professional contexts, inviting dialogue is a sign of confidence, not weakness.

Q4. Correct answer: B — The building is designed to feel as though it has always been part of the site — its edges blur into the terrain.

Why: Option B translates an abstract concept ('dissolving') into vivid, accessible language. Good design communication makes poetic ideas tangible without being vague or overly technical.

Q5. Correct answer: C — We are presenting this as a strong direction rather than a fixed solution — we would welcome your reactions.

Why: Option C is precise: 'strong direction, not fixed solution' is honest and collaborative. A is too closed; B is too uncertain; D defers without engaging.

Q6. Correct answer: C — A coherent framework of ideas that gives meaning and logic to each design decision

Why: A 'design narrative' is the conceptual thread that connects and justifies each decision. It is not a timeline, a legal document, or marketing copy — it is the 'why' that gives the work coherence.

Q7. Correct answer: **B — To emphasise something or make it the most prominent element of the presentation**

Why: 'To foreground' means to bring something to prominence — to make it central and unavoidable in the audience's attention. Widely used in design, cultural studies, and academic writing.

ANSWER KEY

Complete all activities before consulting this page

Activity 02 — Word Sorting

Starting a Narrative	The concept stems from...
Starting a Narrative	What we set out to explore...
Starting a Narrative	At the heart of this proposal...
Starting a Narrative	The driving idea behind this...
Describing a Concept	rooted in contrast
Describing a Concept	a spatial tension between
Describing a Concept	conceptually driven by
Describing a Concept	an honest expression of
Responding to Feedback	That's a useful point —
Responding to Feedback	We can absolutely revisit...
Responding to Feedback	Could you say more about...
Responding to Feedback	That feedback helps us refine...

Activity 03 — Complete the Design Pitch

Sentence 1. Answer: **B — "grew directly out of"**

Why: 'Grew directly out of' suggests the design emerged organically from a real observation or need — not an arbitrary choice.

Sentence 2. Answer: **A — "we chose to connect"**

Why: 'We chose to connect' is clean, active, and decisive — signalling an intentional design decision.

Sentence 3. Answer: **C — "is in direct dialogue with"**

Why: 'In dialogue with' implies a two-way, active relationship between building and context — not just a one-directional influence.

Sentence 4. Answer: **D — "we would like to reframe"**

Why: 'Reframe' means to present a challenge in a new, productive light — constructive, confident, and solution-oriented.

Sentence 5. Answer: **A — "it is an attempt to make"**

Why: 'It is an attempt to make' is both ambitious and honest — it elevates the project without overpromising.

MY SCORE

ACTIVITY	MAX	MY SCORE
Activity 01 — Multiple Choice	7	/ 7
Activity 02 — Word Sorting	12	/ 12
Activity 03 — Complete the Pitch	5	/ 5
TOTAL	24	/ 24